PRE-COLONIAL THEATRE

Pre-Colonial Performance in Nigeria

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

What theatre looked like before the colonial encounter: festival, masquerade, oral epic, praise poetry and the performance of everyday life.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- festival
- masquerade
- oral epic
- praise poetry
- the market square

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The question of the word

Whether pre-colonial Nigeria had "theatre" depends on what you mean by the word. If theatre requires a written play, a hired actor and a paying audience, then it did not. If theatre is a performance, in a marked space, before an audience, with costume, music and a story, then it was everywhere.

Nigerian scholars have argued the second position since the 1970s: the festival is a theatre, the masquerade is a play, the praise-singer is a performer with a text. The argument matters because it decides where the history of Nigerian theatre begins.

Festival as form

The great festivals - Egungun, Gelede, Osun, Eyo, Ekpo, mmanwu, Bori - are annual performances with fixed roles, costumes, music, choreography and an audience that knows the story. They take place in a defined space and follow a structure: procession, arrival, display, contest, departure.

Their theatre is not a representation of something that happened elsewhere; it is an event in which the community participates. That is why the audience is not passive, and why a festival cannot simply be transferred to a proscenium stage without becoming something else.

Masquerade

The masquerade is the most theatrical of the pre-colonial forms: a masked figure who is believed to be a spirit, costumed and concealed, who speaks in a changed voice and moves in a choreographed way. The mask is a character, the costume is a body, and the performance is a negotiation between the wearer, the society and the audience.

The masquerade also carries authority: it can judge, punish, bless and legislate. A theatre that borrows the masque without understanding its authority borrows the costume and loses the meaning.

Oral narrative and praise

The griot, the praise-singer and the storyteller performed history, satire and moral argument in a solo turn, with music, gesture and audience response. The ijala, the ijala chanters, the udje song contests and the tale-telling of the compound are the pre-colonial playhouse: one performer, an audience, a text held in memory and a performance that changes every night.

Modern Nigerian playwrights have gone back to these forms deliberately - Soyinka to Ogun and the masque, Rotimi to the epic, Osofisan to the festival - and the shelf's post-colonial titles show what they made of them.

The evidence problem

There is no script. The evidence for pre-colonial performance is the performance itself, the objects used in it, the oral tradition that surrounds it, and the accounts of outsiders - travellers, missionaries, colonial officers - whose descriptions are useful and interested.

Treat the outsider's account as evidence of what an outsider saw, not as the truth of the event. Where a missionary describes a masquerade as superstition, a historian reads a performance with authority, and both readings are in the sentence.

The best method is participation with permission: attend, watch, ask, record, and let the practitioners correct your description. Then compare what they say with what the archive says. The gap is the history, and it is where a student can make an original contribution rather than repeat a textbook.

From performance to play

The line from festival to written drama runs through adaptation, and the adaptations are the evidence. Rotimi's Kurunmi takes a historical episode and gives it a Greek shape; Soyinka's Death and the King's Horseman takes a colonial incident and a Yoruba metaphysical frame; Osofisan's festival plays take the form and turn its politics.

Read one adaptation beside the tradition it draws on. Ask what was kept, what was changed, and what the change does to the argument. That comparison is the core of a Nigerian drama course.

Exercises

1. Describe one festival you have attended as a performance: space, roles, costume, music, audience, text.
2. Compare a masquerade with a masked character in a modern play, and list what changes when the mask moves indoors.
3. Collect and transcribe a praise poem or folk tale, noting the performer's gestures and the audience's responses.

Where to read more

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

Henry John Drewal and Margaret Thompson Drewal, Gelede (1983)

Wole Soyinka, Myth, Literature and the African World (1976)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.